

Buddha Day Address: What Was the Mindset of the Bodhisatta When He Left His Family and What Made Him Carry On?

Bhante Bodhidhamma · Dharma Talks · 37:03

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa (three times) — Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed Noble, and fully Self-Enlightened One.

I want to start with a quote from somebody who sent me an email: "I thought I had a pretty good grasp on death, but I can't get a handle on it right now. It all just seems so futile and pointless, all the striving. Whether it's striving to earn enough money, striving to maintain ethics, striving to make good memories, what's the point when you just end up a photograph on someone's computer?"

Now, you might be thinking to yourself, today we're celebrating the Buddha and his life, why is this monk making me depressed? Well, the reason that this caught me was not only because of its poignancy, but also there's a truthfulness about it, and it gives us a feeling for why the Buddha should leave his family.

You've got a 29-year-old — this is the story told around the Buddha — and he leaves his wife, his family (that would have been a long extended family in those days, very close) and a newly born child whom he calls Rahula, meaning chains. We have these pictures of him having a peek and then obviously getting on his horse and shooting off into the homeless life.

Men and women, of course, have left their families for various reasons. War, for instance, is a regular one. But he was living in a place which had peace. It was a small clan that was living in the south of present-day Nepal, part of the greater kingdom of Kosala. His father was the head man, head honcho. So he would have had a bit of influence, a good future to look forward to. He was a Kshatriya, which meant the warrior caste.

The caste system was fairly well established. The Brahmins were still considered second class in his area. More to the east, towards present-day Bangladesh, it seems they'd become first, the top of the caste system. They were the mouths of Brahma, and the Kshatriyas were the shoulders, and all the rest were the body and the legs. That image of a caste system, quite rigid.

His life would have been fairly pleasant. He wouldn't have been toiling as such, messing about most of the time, I would have thought — practising maybe a couple of arts, a couple of the martial arts, generally talking about government and all the stuff that was going on, but generally not a stressful life. So something in him drove him. Even around that time there's nothing to suggest that there was a close death

or anything like that, although remember his mother had died at childbirth, so I'm sure that hangs somewhere in a person's memory.

It's the way this person puts it, you see: "I thought I had a pretty good grasp on death." I think most of us would say that. We've got a pretty good grasp on it. And then somebody close dies, or it's our time, and then you suddenly realise that this grasp hasn't got such a good hold. You can't get a handle on it, you see — death shocks you. The reason is that death is so final. That's it, isn't it? Everything is lost, you see, at death.

I remember there was a little joke about an elderly lady who died, who was very rich, and they asked the solicitor, "How much did she leave? What did she leave?" And he said, "Everything." That's it — everything. When it touches upon you then you get that feeling of ungroundedness, that floatiness, that fear, that anxiety, and that sense of uselessness, desperation, meaninglessness.

That takes us to the existentialists of the middle of the last century — people like Albert Camus, who said that consciousness was absurd. That was the general existential position, that consciousness itself is absurd. In other words, there was no reason for it, and it was completely absurd to suffer. So Camus' idea was, well, enjoy life while you can, and if you can't, well, jump. Get rid of it. What's the point? So here he has got into this worthlessness, this meaninglessness of life.

That gives us some idea, maybe, of the Buddha's mental state when he left. Because in those times, the horror wasn't this finishing, wasn't this annihilation. It was this continuous onward going — that you'd be reborn again as a human being over and over again. There didn't seem to be an escape from it at all. Although there were teachers who said there was an escape, it was usually into some higher realm, and it was all predicated on a particular person's experience — mainly, from the Buddha's point of view, as he came to find out, based on your meditative experiences.

We have these absorption states which are very refined states of mind. So if you were to die in that state, or you were an adept at getting into that state, then you would be reborn into this higher realm. That actually still exists in the cosmology of Buddhism, Theravāda Buddhism.

We have to capture him at that moment there of, in a sense, a desperation which comes with meaninglessness — the whole point of having to come back again and again. So it's with that, of course, that he goes on his search, and he goes out with the hope of actually discovering, as he would put it later, the end of suffering. But actually, I think, in his own mind, it would have been the escape from rebirthing, from reincarnation, constant reincarnation.

When he practises with the first two teachers, remember he gets these very deep mental states, and again it's this idea that if you die in that state, you'll be reborn there, and that you'll be there forever in this beautiful state. But as he was a human being, he kept falling out of it. So there was a suggestion there, must have been a suggestion in him, that even though he was born in this heavenly place, the *kamma*, the

energy that would keep him there would eventually run out, and he'd fall back into being a human being. That's basically also some of the teaching that we have from the Buddha, that in this rebirthing process, depending upon the energy or the amount of power that there is in that state, you can fall from it when it's been exhausted. You would fall down or perhaps move up with it, who knows.

So he found that to be not satisfactory. It wasn't giving him some way of putting an end to this constant rebirth.

When he practises self-mortification, that's a completely different philosophy. That's the understanding that the soul is trapped in the body and the body itself is a manifestation of your bad *kamma*. So the idea is to try and get rid of your body, especially the appetites of the body. So you deny yourself in order to reduce your appetites for the body, reduce your attachment to this life form. By doing so, the soul would then untrap itself and rise to heaven and stay there. This would have been an understanding of the Jains, for instance.

You can see there's a lot going on. There were also materialists who, like this person, believed that once you die, that was it. And there were people who didn't believe in good works or bad works, that they would have an effect. They would say that if you went to one side of the Ganges, full of compassion and love and joy, and came down the other side with hatred, greed and aversion, it didn't actually matter because it was all fate, it was all driven by circumstance.

You can see he's in this area of tremendous fermentation, a bit like today really. If you look at the human race, all over the place. You get this feeling that there was a lot of investigation going on about the purpose of life.

He goes out, you see, with this sort of despairing state, this feeling about the meaninglessness of life. When, of course, he becomes fully liberated, what he discerns is how we create this suffering. The whole accent then turns upon who is actually — or what is actually — causing this rebirth.

Now whether we believe in rebirth as something that happens after death doesn't really matter, because all we have is this present moment and we must be rebirthing now. We must be in a process of recreating ourselves all the time. It's not a case of launching it into an after-death process. That really remains within your own personal belief, your own personal perspective on life. If you've had a past life experience, then you probably have some proof within yourself that you go on. But if you haven't, then you take it on, as we say, confidence for the while and hope for the best.

The fact that there might be annihilation upon death is in itself not that tremendously horrible, because once you're annihilated, well, at least there's no suffering. That's it, it's gone. But the thing is that it's really to catch the teaching as a moment-to-moment teaching — that actually here and now we are rebirthing — and to understand what's actually empowering that.

When we talk about rebirth, if we just go through what it is to be a human being from moment to

moment, first of all, there's this body. Now we know this body is made up of something like 10 trillion cells and it's got 100 trillion guest cells. These cells are constantly dying, reproducing themselves. So this body is not the body that we were born with. Well, they tell you it's not the body you had seven years ago.

That's something really — when you look into a mirror, you can say to your face, "You weren't here seven years ago and you won't be here in seven years." It's like reminding ourselves that this feeling of being me, this hardness, this constancy, this substantiality that we have a feeling around this body, this me, actually doesn't have a basis.

When you look at the body like that, and then you ask yourself things like, "Well, what do I know about my body?" You might know things theoretically — you might know, for instance, what your liver does — but do you know what it's doing now? Well, it better be doing a good job, because it's supposed to be doing a good job now, right?

If you ask yourself things like, "What would I have known about the brain before modern science?" All I know actually about the brain is that I'm up here somewhere, aren't I? Most times I'm talking to you, I'm talking to you up here somewhere, about half an inch or so behind this bone. I feel myself to be up here, and I'm talking to you, and I haven't a clue what's inside there at all. I've no direct experience of it.

If you look at me now, what do you know of your face? It's a big hole, isn't it? It's a big hole and you're looking through it. It's weird, isn't it? And then I can see your face, but you can't see yours. Very strange situation we're in.

If you grasp the fact that the body itself has its own life form, it's actually doing its own thing. As you know, it can let us down terribly.

Then if you look at your heart life, your emotional life, well, it's all over the place, isn't it? You get up feeling great and then you're all over. There's no control over it. There's no absolute control. You can push things away. You can suppress stuff and put your mind on something which makes you happy, which lifts your spirits. But apart from that, you're still going to have to deal with this stuff because, well, we know it's all under there.

So the heart itself is in this constant process of changing, of moving. In meditation, if we look closely, what happens is that we put words to it. We say, "Oh, I'm angry," or "I'm depressed," or "I'm happy, I'm joyful now." But actually when you go into it, and you actually feel what's there, well, it's just a feeling. It's just a feeling, like a sensation, like an itch which you want to scratch and then it disappears. There's nothing substantial about it at all, except that we give it a substantiality by saying it's me.

Something happens with the body and the heart whenever we turn it into something that I am. It's impossible to escape. As soon as I say to myself, "Oh, I'm depressed," that's it, isn't it? I'm depressed — where are we going to go from there? It's like Prozac, isn't it? There's no escape from "I am depressed." Worse is "I am happy." Because in the midst of "I am happy," I am happy. And then the happiness goes.

Then what am I? See?

This process of identifying with it, identifying with the emotional state, gives it some sort of solidity, some sort of permanency, some sort of reality. But when we distance from it and we look at it and we feel it, it's just a feeling. It's just a feeling. Mental feeling, maybe, but it's just a feeling.

Even more fleeting are these thoughts. When we see these thoughts come and go, most times we're caught up in them. And for most times, rightly so — we're having a conversation, we're on the telephone or whatever. But what we notice when we come to meditate, it goes completely haywire. We've no control over it at all. Then you realise that maybe that's the way it is in daily life and I'm just fooling myself.

You realise that no thought ever repeats itself. There's no repetition. Everything is absolutely creative. Therefore there's no ability to hold on to something. You can't hold on either to this body — it's changing — to the heart states, although they're very similar. One state of depression generally feels very much like the next. But they're all completely different in the sense of what's actually happening in this moment.

The idea of trying to hold on to something, which is what we do, it becomes ridiculous. See? That's one of the drives of our meditation. When I say meditation, I'm not just talking about in a sitting posture, but even in ordinary daily life, just to be aware at the end of a day that the day is gone. That's it. It's finished. Complete. At the end of a meal, it's gone. Finished. You can't do anything about it. You never come back. That's it — and feel the grief.

It's just catching that impermanency of things, that absolute annihilation. That's where we get the feeling of annihilation, in the present moment, that every moment actually annihilates. Phenomenally speaking — in other words, the consciousness that we have, what we experience, even though the stimulus is given to us from the outside world — everything that we have completely comes to an end and it annihilates. That's it. It's gone.

Concentrating on that, concentrating on the end of things, brings us right face to face with this problem of death. That's where I think the Buddha must have been when he started on his journey.

Something, as we know, something changed in him when all these things failed. There was this change of way of looking at things. We can only imagine that, having been to all these teachers, he was in a bit of a state of despair, really, because there was no answer. Nobody had shown him. He'd been through all the exercises. He knew all the arguments, because later on, after his liberation, he could argue his point with all the other teachers that were around, all the other philosophers and people like that. Yet he'd come to this point of desperation.

So there was a flip, there was a turnaround. The turnaround was basically: instead of chasing for happiness, instead of trying to find happiness, he now turns inward to see how he creates suffering. What his discovery is, you might say, is that the world we're creating is the one that we are creating. Even in this room now we have as many rooms as there are people, and when you grasp that — if you grasp that

actually...

Everything that you're experiencing now is being manufactured within here, within this body, the heart process as well, and the feeling of the room. It's all being manufactured through the sense bases of the body and what the brain does with it and the mind does with it. And we have this consciousness which is only limited by phenomena. I'm only limited to what I can see by these walls. If these walls weren't here, then my conscience would be able to contain the whole area. If I was stuck in the middle of the universe, I'd be able to contain the whole universe because my conscience is as loud or as wide as what comes in through my sense bases. But it's all here, it's all me, it's all projections. None of it actually really exists outside me as something I can experience. That's why I can't experience the world you experience.

So there's some sort of disconnection between us. And we can only contact each other through language, through a certain empathy, through a certain feel. But you can't actually be in another person's world. We're trapped in this consciousness. We're trapped within our own world, which is a terrifying idea if you think about it.

So when you begin to realize that, then the problem is how do I then make this world that I'm manufacturing somewhere where I want to continue living, where I want to actually enjoy life rather than being always in a state of conflict. And that's when we come back into this process and realize this whole thing about desire and attachment, and aversion, and having a relationship with what we're experiencing, always to do with either wanting, grasping, or pushing away, or running away.

And then, as you come behind that, you find that there's somebody that wants to do this. So your original, the original problem lies deep, deep, deep within our psyche, all around this idea of, who am I? This sense of identity. And in our meditation, when we distance something from us, as those of you in the room this morning, and those who've been meditating anyway, what we're doing is we're finding a kernel of identity within ourselves which is separating out from the psychophysical organism with its sensations and feelings, emotions, moods, thoughts and images.

Now, that's a very strange place. Think about it. Because now you are the observer. You're actually saying to yourself, in so many words, I am the observer of, right? The perceiver can't be the perceived. You can't have the two. And I am, my feeling is that I am this observer. I am this feeler within what everything's going on in my mind. So, I'm an alien. Right? I mean, I shouldn't be here. I've lost my identity at a certain level with the body, heart and mind. It's a very strange place to be.

Now, the thing is that when you get into that place, when you get into that place and you're very quiet and you're in that place, just have a glance back into it and find out what's not there. And that's where you get the teaching of the Buddha about not me, not mine. So this not me, not mine is not a statement that there isn't a self, that there isn't a soul, that there isn't something which is transcendent. There's no way in the scriptures he says there is no self. It's a teaching tool. What he's saying is everything that becomes an object to your awareness, you should be saying to yourself, the perceiver can't be the perceived, it can't be

me. So that's not me and it's not mine.

I can't possess something which is, if I don't have a relationship with something, I can't possess it. And most of our possession, remember, is either some sort of emotional clinging or a legal fiction. I mean, if somebody steals your mobile, you might go around saying, somebody stole my mobile, it's not yours anymore. It's just possession. You have to watch the way that the mind works in terms of identifying and possessing something.

So now, as we go down through the layers, so here we are, we've looked at the body and it's just a pile of cells constantly changing completely out of my control. I mean, I can't get into a cell and tell it to divide. I can't do anything with the cellular makeup of my body. When it comes to my heart level, I can allow the heart to manifest and it will slowly heal itself of its problems and I can build up the heart through the same process of imagination so that I actually have a beautiful heart, a beautiful mind and I can do something about thinking so there's some way of controlling it if you consider a driver in a car for those of you who have cars, those who can drive.

When you're driving and you're actually in the driving, you're in the zone driving, you and the car are one and there's this feeling of total control and it's only when the wheel drops off that you realise that actually you're not in control, you freak out. So there's that sense of identifying which gives you a sense of control. This is the problem with identity. And so here we are constantly disidentifying with things. And in so doing, undermining the relationship that identity creates, which is wanting to control.

And that wanting to control manifests in terms of desire and attachment. So as soon as something is pleasant, you want to control it. You want to maintain it. You want to increase it. And as soon as something is unpleasant, you want to get rid of it. So we're in constant conflict with the way things are. Now I'm talking within ourselves. I'm talking within ourselves, a psychology which is the negative part of us. Don't confuse this with compassion and love, which is coming from a wisdom center, where you're trying to do something, but from a very different angle. And it's coming out of trying to find an honest and a skillful relationship. That's what we're moving towards when we develop this goodwill, this compassion and joy. And that, of course, brings a happiness which is not clinging. Love doesn't cling. Love allows.

So this was his discovery. And it's interesting that as it's put in the mythology of his teaching, the first teaching was around these Four Noble Truths, just laying the platform that there is suffering. So this is it, there is death. And it's like really laying the platform about life as unsatisfactory. That we shouldn't be seeking permanent happiness in life. The joys in life come and go. Simple as that.

And then the second noble truth to point to the very kernel, which is the problem, the desire, which is to do with our relationship to things, right? This English word desire is a bit, it's not quite right because you can have a good desire, an honest desire. I'm translating the word *taṇhā*, which is often translated as thirst or craving. But all it is, is desire based on wrong understanding, desire based on delusive understanding.

And then the third noble truth, a really clear declaration that there is an end to suffering. You can't get clearer than that. No Western psychotherapist has said that. They all say you can get to an accommodation with life, but nobody has ever stated in the West that you can come to the end of suffering in this very life. Not that I know of anyway. Is there one? No, I don't think there is.

So, and of course, the fourth one is how to get there, the Eightfold Path. And the top of the Eightfold Path is this right understanding. And right view is probably a better way of expressing it. And to begin to turn the way we see things, to turn them around. Constant reminder about how things arise and pass away. Constant reminder that every time suffering arises, there must be something wrong within my relationship to what's happening here. There's something in me that's got it wrong. And to look into it and take responsibility for it. And the fact that not to substantiate things, not to make this sense of I so strong.

And you do that, of course, by connecting with other people. One example is the Buddha visits these three monks who are liberated, completely liberated. He calls them the Anuruddhas. And he asks one of them, how is it that you live so peacefully together? And the kernel statement within the discourse is, well, when I get up in the morning, I say to myself, what if I do what the others do? What if I put aside what I want to do and do what the others want to do?

Now, how many of you get up in the morning and say that to yourselves? What if I put aside what I want to do and do what the others want to do? Now, frankly, in a community, that only works if everybody says it. I should end up being slightly abused. Because everybody will make you do what they want to do. So there has to be that reciprocity.

So we can see now, as we go through this, just the amazing insight that the Buddha had. I mean, I couldn't have got there myself without the Buddha. I mean, I couldn't have got there without my teachers who told me to look this way. I mean, I'd still be a raving lunatic. I would never have been able to have grasped this were it not for the direction from my teachers and they going right back to the Buddha who made that kernel insight.

So that's where he stands within our particular tradition. He's the founder. He's the fountain of all that insight that we have. And he's the exemplar because he himself went through this whole process. It wasn't something that he thought up. It was something that he himself personally experienced about himself. And in the sense that he's an archetype because all of us have to go through this process of renunciation.

And if you look at any spiritual tradition, it doesn't matter what religion it is, you'll find it's always a process of renunciation. And the renunciation, remember, isn't the denial of the world. It's not a world negative thing. It's a denial of seeing the world as the place to become perfectly happy in. And what we're aiming towards is that when we are in a state of joyfulness, we can actually fully enjoy it without wanting it to be repeated, without holding on to it. And that when we're in a state of misery and pain and all that, that we're able to be patient with it and just bear with it. That's where we're going to.

So the Buddha, when he died, he was praised afterwards for his patience, for his bearing of his illness. He had food poisoning. He had food poisoning. And even there, just finally, even there before he died, he's able to encourage people. All compounded things arise and pass away. Strive diligently for your liberation. Always ask, what will be our last words? Why me? There was a lovely cartoon with all these ladies around, this elderly lady who was dying, and she's looking at them and saying, why me? Why not one of you?

So you can see that that's where it's leading us towards anyway. That's what we mean by liberation from suffering. We don't mean liberation from the pains and the emotional stuff around life. We mean a liberation from it.

In fact, just to bring the talk to an end, could you bring me that thing, Marion? That picture frame. It's not a picture. Just a picture frame, yeah. I didn't think I'd need this, but I said I had it. It's just that when you start talking, you never know where you'll end up. Thanks a lot, mate.

So this is an amazing woman. I mean, she died in 1991. She was 90 years old. And here she's telling us what it's like to be fully liberated. I mean, this is a very clear, straightforward statement. She says body, mind and essence are all distinct and separate realities. The body, the mind, and then she's talked about essence. So just keep that word in mind.

And absolutely everything is known. It's not as though she doesn't experience things as they come up. When she talks about earth, water, fire and wind, she's talking about her sensual experience, which is weight, temperature, movement, feeling, memory, thought and consciousness. So they all come up. Sound, sight, smells, taste, touches, emotions, anger, greed and delusion are all known.

Now note that, anger, greed and delusion. So the enlightened person hasn't got rid of all the habitual little tendencies within the mind, right? So they're known when they come up, and I know them all as they exist in their own natural states. But no matter how much I'm exposed to them, I'm unable to detect even an instant when they have any power over my heart. So now notice that word, over my heart. No power over my heart.

And they arise and cease, they're forever changing, but the presence that knows them never changes for an instant. It is forever unborn and undying, and this is the end of suffering. Presence.

So she uses three words to try and point to something which is indescribable. It's an essence, it's a heart, and it's a presence. And our job in our practice is to actually begin to recognize what that is. And we recognize it more easily by constantly making everything that we experience an object of our experience, by pointing to it.

So I can only hope my words have been of some assistance and it has not caused even greater confusion. And that you will, by your own deliberate and devoted practice, soon liberate yourself from all suffering. Sooner rather than later.

Sadhu, sadhu, sadhu.

Delayed but yet sweet to the ear. Three teachers.

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